

Deputy Vice Chancellor Seed Funding Proposal 2026–2027

Supporting Multidisciplinary Research

1. Overview of the Scheme

Applications are invited for up to 10 seed grants, each valued at a maximum of **\$50,000** to support high-quality, multidisciplinary research projects that strengthen institutional capability, develop innovative approaches, generate pilot data, and lay a strong foundation for future external funding. The scheme aims to catalyse new collaborations or extend existing collaborations across the University of Canberra and encourage early-stage research activity that positions teams for success in competitive funding schemes. The seed grants are funded from the Commonwealth Government Research Block Grant funding allocated to the University of Canberra for 2026.

Projects must be co-led by researchers from at least two distinct research areas (e.g., different faculties, disciplines or research units). Individual staff members may participate in no more than two applications. Proposals led by a midcareer researcher (MCR) in the Chief Investigator role will be prioritised, and **all projects must include the participation of at least one early career researcher (ECR)**.

Completed applications must be submitted to seedgrants@canberra.edu.au by **30 April 2026**. Applications will be assessed using the published evaluation rubric, and applicants will be notified of outcomes by **30 May 2026**.

Funds must be expended by **30 November 2027**, and successful teams will be required to submit an **End-of-Project Report**, including a budget acquittal, using the provided reporting template.

2. Rationale

The Deputy Vice Chancellor Seed Funding Scheme strengthens UC's multidisciplinary research ecosystem by enabling new and renewed collaborations across faculties and research units and supports mission-led research aligned with the Reconnected Framework 2025-2027 and the Research Plan 2024-2028. The scheme prioritises projects that advance UCs applied, mission-led research agenda by addressing significant knowledge gaps, developing innovative methods, and contributing to the University's growing impact profile.

Funding is directed towards research aligned with [UC's strategic themes](#): climate, environment and public policy; health, wellbeing and human performance; society and civic capacity; and technology, learning and development, and to research that demonstrates clear pathways to social, economic, environmental, cultural or wellbeing impact, consistent with the UC Research Impact Framework.

3. Objectives

The 2026–2027 Deputy Vice Chancellor Seed Funding Scheme aims to:

- Foster new, strategically aligned cross-faculty, discipline or research unit partnerships by reducing financial and administrative barriers to collaboration.

- Strengthen UC's research capability and performance by supporting high-quality, innovative projects with strong potential for scalability and outcomes.
- Enable external funding readiness, providing pilot data and collaboration structures suitable for schemes such as ARC Discovery, Linkage, MRFF, NHMRC partnership calls, industry grants and philanthropic funding.
- Support the development of emerging researchers by encouraging strong participation from early-career academics, alongside mid-career researchers and interdisciplinary teams.
- Advance UC's contribution to social, economic, environmental and cultural impact, in alignment with national research priorities and institutional strategy.

4. Eligibility

4.1 Team Composition

- Projects must be co-led by researchers from at least two distinct research areas (e.g., different faculties, disciplines or research units).
- Projects must be led by a UC mid-career researcher (Level B to D)
- Teams must include a minimum of one early career researcher (ECR) who will lead a defined component of the project. A senior academic is to be named as a mentor to support the ECR's development.
- All academic staff with contracts extending beyond the project period are eligible to apply.

4.2 Nature of Collaboration

- Projects must demonstrate new collaboration or an extension of an existing collaboration. They cannot be already funded from other internal or external sources.
- External collaborators may be included, provided the project's core focus remains internal multidisciplinary research.

5. Funding

5.1 Eligible Expenditure

The total funding available for each seed grant is up to \$50,000 (excl GST).

- Research assistance (salaries, on-costs).
- Travel directly related to conducting research (subject to UC travel policies).
- Consumables and analysis expenses.
- Software licences.
- External equipment use charges.
- Minor equipment (retained by faculty, not individuals).
- Publication costs (where read and publish arrangements are unsuitable).

5.2 Ineligible Expenditure

- Academic staff salary buy-out or teaching relief.
- Salaries or travel for external collaborators.
- HDR stipend supplementation.
- Costs for ongoing research projects.
- Conference registration/travel.

- Dissemination costs (reports, design work) unless directly tied to impact pathways.
- Equipment over \$1,000 or standard computing equipment (laptops/desktops).

Funds will be allocated for expenditure in 2026 - 2027. **Any unspent funds will be returned to the Research Office at the end of the project period.**

6. Application Requirements

Applications must present a clear, compelling and strategically aligned case for investment. Submissions must address the following components:

1. Significance & Innovation

- Articulate the research problem, opportunity, or knowledge gap, including its relevance to the broader societal context.
- Demonstrate novelty and innovation through new knowledge, methods, or interdisciplinary approaches.
- Explain how the project contributes to emerging research frontiers and strengthens UC's national or global positioning.

2. Strategic Alignment

- Demonstrate alignment with UC institutional research priorities, faculty strategies, Deputy Vice Chancellor's strategic themes, or identified capability areas.
- Describe contributions to institutional goals, such as enhanced partnerships, improved research performance indicators, or strengthened impact pathways.

3. Feasibility

Provide a clear project plan with defined objectives, methods, and milestones suitable for an 18-month seed project. Justify the chosen methodology and demonstrate feasibility with available expertise and resources.

- Outline team capability, including complementary expertise, leadership roles, and mentoring structures where relevant, consistent with cross faculty, discipline or research unit, co-leadership expectations.

4. Outcomes & Impact

- Identify expected outputs such as pilot data, publications, prototypes, methodological developments, or partnerships.
- Demonstrate clear return on investment, outlining how the project will deliver value and strengthen future research capability.
- Provide evidence of pathways to external funding or translation, including targeted schemes and partnership development.
- Describe anticipated social, economic, environmental or cultural impacts aligned with institutional and national priorities.

5. Budget & Justification

- Submission of an itemised budget aligned with project activities.

- Justification of each cost, demonstrating value for money and adherence to funding rules (e.g., exclusions on laptops, equipment >\$1,000, and conference travel).
- Identify any in-kind contributions from faculties.

7. Evaluation and Assessment Criteria

7.1 Evaluation

A review panel (ADRs or nominated representatives), with external member(s) chaired by the Deputy Vice-Chancellor, will assess all eligible applications. Any panel member with a conflict of interest, including those named on an application will withdraw from all related deliberations.

- Applications will be scored against the assessment criteria.
- Scores will be aggregated to determine overall ranking, with panel moderation to ensure consistency and fairness.

In addition to the formal scoring, the panel may apply strategic weighting or preference (5%) to proposals that clearly demonstrate:

1. Support for Early (ECRs) and Midcareer Researchers (MCRs)

Projects led by MCRs, or substantially involving, ECRs, particularly those where the scheme provides a meaningful opportunity for capability development and research independence.

2. Multidisciplinary or Cross Research Unit Collaboration

Proposals that build new research collaborations or extend existing collaborations across Faculties, Disciplines and Centres, consistent with the scheme's objective of fostering cross faculty partnerships.

3. Strong External Partner Engagement

Projects that include significant contributions, commitments, or leverage from industry, government, community organisations, or national research facilities.

Final Selection

The review panel will make final recommendations to the Deputy Vice Chancellor, who will approve funding allocations. Decisions will consider:

- Merit based assessment according to the criteria
- Strategic portfolio balance across Faculties and research themes
- Available funding and institutional priorities

7.2 Assessment Criteria

Assessors will evaluate:

Criterion	Description	Weighting
1. Significance & Innovation	Strength of the research problem definition, clarity of the opportunity, novelty of approach, and contribution to emerging research frontiers.	25%

2. Strategic Alignment	Alignment with UC institutional research priorities, faculty strategies, and Deputy Vice Chancellor themes; contribution to institutional performance, partnerships, rankings and impact pathways.	10%
3. Feasibility	Quality and realism of the project plan; methodological rigour; suitability for 18-month delivery; capability and complementarity of the cross-faculty team (including mentoring where relevant)	20%
4. Outcomes & Impact	Strength of expected outputs; return on investment; pathways to external funding (specific schemes); potential social, economic, environmental or cultural impacts.	20%
5. Budget & Justification	Appropriateness of requested funds; value for money; adherence to scheme rules; clarity of justification; inclusion of in-kind contributions where applicable.	20%
6. Strategic Selectors (Applied by Panel)	Additional preference may be applied to proposals demonstrating: • meaningful MCR leadership and ECR involvement • multidisciplinary / cross-faculty collaboration • strong external partner engagement or leverage • high potential where other internal funding mechanisms are unavailable	5% (discretionary weighting applied during panel moderation)

8. Funding Management

Seed funding will be transferred from the Office of the Deputy Vice-Chancellor to the relevant faculty for local financial administration. Each funded project will be established in the Pure research management system, with associated milestones recorded to support progress monitoring and reporting.

9. Reporting Requirements

9.1 Project Progress Report

A mid-project Progress Report is required, and each funded project will be entered into the Pure research management system with associated milestones for ongoing monitoring. All Progress Reports must be uploaded to Pure to maintain institutional oversight and accurate milestone tracking, and project teams are responsible for ensuring timely submission to the correct project record.

9.2 Project Completion Presentation

At the conclusion of each funded project, research teams will deliver a Project Completion Presentation to showcase key outcomes, emerging impact pathways, collaborations, and external funding readiness. This presentation complements the End-of-Project Report and provides an opportunity for knowledge sharing across faculties and research units.

Presentations will be scheduled during a dedicated DVC Seed Funding Showcase Session. Each team will provide:

- A 15-minute presentation, followed by time for questions.
- A summary of project aims, methodologies, key findings, and research outputs.
- Evidence of emerging research impact and partnerships.
- A brief overview of external funding submissions and future plans.

- Reflections on collaboration, capability development, and next steps.

Showcase sessions may be conducted in person, hybrid, or fully online, depending on availability and audience needs. Presenting teams may include multiple investigators but must involve at least one project lead. These presentations form a vital part of UC's multidisciplinary research community-building, enabling cross-faculty visibility, knowledge exchange, and opportunities for future collaboration and investment.

9.3 End-of-Project Report Requirements

All funded projects must submit an End-of-Project Report at the conclusion of the project period. The Final Report must be submitted as a single PDF document, with any supporting files attached separately to:

seedgrants@canberra.edu.au

Subject line: *Deputy Vice Chancellor Seed Funding – Final Report – [Project Title]*

Reports are due within six weeks of project completion, unless otherwise advised.

The Final Report must include the following components:

1. Budget Acquittal

- A clear breakdown of how all project funds were allocated and expended.
- Explanation of any variances between the approved budget and actual expenditure.
- Confirmation that spending complied with scheme rules and UC financial policies.

2. Research Outputs

Provide a comprehensive list of outputs generated during the project, including (where applicable):

- Peer reviewed publications, conference outputs, or working paper-reviewed publications, conference outputs, or working papers
- Research datasets, software, code, prototypes or tools
- Public or stakeholder engagement activities
- Workshops, seminars, or outreach events
- Knowledge translation products (reports, briefs, guidelines, models)

3. External Funding Pathways

- Details of external grant applications submitted during or immediately after the project.
- Planned or targeted schemes for future funding (ARC, MRFF, NHMRC, industry, philanthropic, or government programs).
- Evidence of strengthened readiness for external funding.

4. Research Impact and Partnerships

Include evidence of:

- Engagement with industry, government, community, or policy partners

- New or strengthened collaborations arising from the project
- Impact planning activities and any emerging impact pathways
- Contributions to social, economic, environmental or cultural outcomes

5. Data and Deliverable Management

- Details of datasets, code, software, or digital research outputs deposited in recognised institutional repositories (e.g., UC Research Repository).
- Persistent links (e.g., DOI or handle) where publicly accessible.
- Data management compliance statements, if required.

Appendix 1

Templates

All applications must be submitted using the required template, submissions that do not comply with the template and seed funding guidelines will not be considered eligible.

Application Template

Project Title
<i>(Enter project title)</i>

Research Team: A minimum of two leads from different Faculties are required		
Name	Faculty/Role in Project	Expertise & Relevant Track Record

Significance & Innovation: <i>Describe the research problem, opportunity, or knowledge gap. Outline the novelty of the approach and how the project advances emerging research frontiers. (Max 400 words)</i>

Strategic Alignment: <i>Explain how the project aligns with UC institutional research priorities, faculty strategies, and Research Plan's strategic themes. Identify expected contributions to partnerships, rankings, and/or impact pathways. (Max 200 words)</i>

Feasibility: Provide a clear plan with objectives, methods, milestones, and an 18-month timeline. Outline team capability, expertise, and any mentoring arrangements. (Max 400 words)

Expected Outcomes & Impact: List anticipated outputs (e.g., pilot data, publications, prototypes, partner engagement). Describe the return on investment, pathways to external funding (identify target schemes/rounds), and potential social/economic/environmental/cultural impacts. (Max 200 words)

Workplan & Milestones: Key tasks, timeline, and deliverables for 18-month project.

Task/Milestone	Timeline	Deliverable

Budget & Justification: Itemise the budget and justify each expense. Include any in-kind or faculty contributions. Ensure alignment with funding rules. . Please indicate how you expect to spend the funds **BEFORE 30th November 2027**

Item	Cost	Justification	In-Kind contribution

Ethics requirements

Is ethics approval required?	Yes	No
If yes, has approval processes been factored into the timeframe of the project?	Yes	No

[Please see HREC Meeting Dates](#)

Certification: Signature of each project lead is required, add more lines if required

We certify that we: a) have read and understood the conditions of the grant, b) will acquit the allocated budget as proposed and in accordance with the conditions of the scheme, and c) agree to providing the end-of-project report.

Signature	Date
Signature	Date
Faculty Signature (Associate Dean Research)	Date

Applications involving an Associate Dean Research must be endorsed by the Faculty Dean due to conflict-of-interest requirements of interest requirements.-of-interest requirements.

Progress Report Template

Project Summary: Provide a brief overview of the project aims, research questions, and expected outcomes. Summarise progress to date in accessible, non-technical language. (Max 150 words)

Progress Against Workplan & Milestones: (Align with milestones submitted in the application, as required in the scheme guidelines.)

Task / Milestone	Planned Timeline	Progress to Date	Status (On track / Delayed / Completed)	Comments / Corrective Actions

Research Activities Completed: Detail work undertaken so far, such as data collection, analyses, pilot work, literature reviews, methodological development, partnership or stakeholder engagement. (Max 150 words)

External Funding Pathways – Progress: Outline steps taken towards external funding readiness, such as schemes being targeted, drafts underway, partner discussions, capacity-building activities. Include expected timelines for submission. (Max 150 words)

Budget Expenditure to Date: Please provide a financial progress summary, noting that the scheme requires ongoing monitoring and an end-of-project budget acquittal. Include the following information:

- Total Funds Awarded: \$
- Funds Expended to Date: \$
- Funds Remaining: \$

Item	Approved Budget	Actual Expenditure	Variance	Explanation (if applicable)

Emerging Research Impact & Partnerships: Describe any progress in impact pathways or collaborations. (Max 100 words)

Certification: Signature of each project lead is required, add more lines if required

We certify that this Progress Report is accurate and complete, and that all project funds were expended in accordance with UC financial policies and scheme conditions.

Signature

Date

Signature

Date

End-of-Project Report Template

The end-of-project report must be submitted to the Director, Research, who will acknowledge receipt, and may be drawn upon in future scheme assessments or audited as part of standard compliance processes.

Project Title
<i>(Enter project title)</i>

Budget Acquittal	
Total Funds Awarded	<i>(Enter amount)</i>
Total Funds Expended	<i>(Enter amount)</i>

Item	Approved Budget	Actual Expenditure	Variance	Explanation (if applicable)

Output Type	Details	Status / Link (if applicable)
Publications		
Conference Papers / Presentations		
Datasets		
Software / Code		
Prototypes / Tools		
Engagement Activities (events, workshops)		
Knowledge Translation Products (reports, briefs, guidelines)		

External Funding Activities: <i>Describe external grant applications submitted during the project or immediately following completion. List targeted future schemes - ARC, MRFF, NHMRC, industry, government, philanthropic, and outline readiness for submission.</i>	
Grants submitted	
Pending submissions	
Targeted schemes (with timelines)	
Evidence of enhanced funding readiness	

Research Impact & Partnership Development: <i>Please briefly outline how the project has begun to enable research impact in line with the UC Research Impact Framework. Describe any engagement with industry, government, community, or</i>

policy partners, and note where collaborations have been strengthened. Highlight early indications of influence or relevance beyond academia, and identify any emerging contributions to social, economic, environmental, cultural or wellbeing outcomes.

Data and Deliverable Management: *List datasets, code, software, digital outputs deposited in recognised repositories e.g., Pure.*

Deliverable	Repository Location	Link

Summary of Achievements: *Provide a high-level summary of what the project achieved, its significance, and overall contribution to UC.*

Certification: *Signature of each project lead is required, add more lines if required*

We certify that this Final Report is accurate and complete, and that all project funds were expended in accordance with UC financial policies and scheme conditions.

Signature _____ Date _____

Signature _____ Date _____

Faculty Signature (Associate Dean Research) _____ Date _____

Appendix 2

Key Definitions

Term	Definition
ECR - Early Career Researcher	A researcher who is generally within 5 years of completing their PhD. This period is adjusted to fairly account for recognised career interruptions, such as parental leave, illness, caring responsibilities. These interruptions are normally acknowledged to ensure equitable assessment of research opportunity and achievement.
MCR - Mid-Career Researcher	An academic who is typically 5–15 years post-PhD. An MCR generally holds an academic appointment at Senior Lecturer or Associate Professor level, and the category is capped at an academic Level D. MCRs provide evidence of research independence through high-quality competitive grant applications, strong publication outputs, and leadership of collaborative research projects. They actively contribute to the research ecosystem through mentoring, strategic or operational research planning, and/or industry, government, or community engagement.

Senior Researcher	An established academic, typically beyond 15 years post-PhD, who demonstrates sustained excellence and leadership in research. Senior Researchers commonly hold appointments at Professor or Associate Professor (Level D/E) levels and have a well-recognised record of high-quality research outputs, competitive grant success, and ongoing contribution to disciplinary or interdisciplinary advancement.
Chief Investigator (CI)	A named researcher responsible for the design, leadership and delivery of the project. For this scheme, an MCR.
Collaborating Investigator	A researcher who contributes expertise, methods, data, or supervision but is not leading the project.
Mentor	A senior academic who provides guidance, support and capability development, particularly for the ECR involved in the project.
Multidisciplinary Collaboration	A project team that includes researchers from at least two distinct research areas (different faculties, schools, institutes, or centres).